

Dear Prof. Rob Baltussen and the Department of IQ Health,

My name is Varvara Lazarenko, and I would like to express my strong interest in applying for the research position in 'Patient and Community Involvement in Health Benefit Package Design in Kenya and Rwanda'. This opportunity resonates deeply with my academic background and long-standing motivation to address societal challenges within healthcare systems.

As a graduate of Radboud University's MSc in Medical Biology with a specialization in Science, Management, and Innovation (SMI), I am passionate about making healthcare more sustainable, inclusive, and cost-effective. That is why I am thrilled about this opportunity to contribute to the international research that aims to improve equitable healthcare decision-making in low- and middle-income countries.

My academic background equips me with a solid foundation for this role. Having finished a bachelor's in Biology and a master's in Medical Biology, I gained extensive knowledge in the field and developed a critical understanding of biomedical challenges. Through the SMI track in the second year of my master's, I also acquired valuable insights into the Health Technology Assessment (HTA) and health economics. My master's thesis at HAN University of Applied Sciences included in-depth interviews, deployment of surveys, and a cost-effectiveness analysis using a Markov model – providing me with practical skills highly relevant for this job. Furthermore, I worked on real-world projects such as *"HTA of a Medical Guidance App for International Students in the NL"* and *"A Shared Ownership Model of the Green Corridor."* All these experiences greatly enriched my ability to engage stakeholders and communicate complex findings effectively.

Professionally, I have worked as a Junior Research Assistant at the Faculty of Biology and as an Assistant at a Contract Research Organization. I gained substantial experience in writing academic papers and reports, designing experiments and research protocols, conducting user interviews, preparing clinical documentation, and managing complex data. These roles significantly deepened my understanding of the scientific and healthcare landscapes. This multidisciplinary background gives me a strong platform to address both ethical and practical questions surrounding inclusive decision-making in healthcare.

I am particularly excited about the opportunity to collaborate with researchers in Kenya and Rwanda and to support efforts to strengthen health systems in a meaningful way. This aligns well with my previous academic focus on sustainable innovation and my interest in global health equity.

In addition to my research background, I am fluent in English, have beginner-level French, and have experience working in international teams and mentoring students from diverse backgrounds. I am also eager to contribute to the department's educational activities, as teaching and mentorship are areas I deeply value. I am excited to further develop my skills within the dynamic environment of IQ Health, and I see this position as a meaningful step toward a long-term academic and policy-engaged career.

Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my background and interests can contribute to the SHARP project.

Warm regards,
Varvara Lazarenko